early 2002. But during the chaos in the immediate aftermath of the 2001 attack, they misjudged

the ISI as a great partner in its war against terror,' said Asthana.

The R&AW spy also recalled his meeting with General Hamid Gul sometime in 2002 at an undisclosed location in an European country. It was a chance encounter, revealed Asthana. He was pacing around the reception area and General Gul, well dressed in a black coat, appeared out of a lift in the hotel lobby and walked to him.

'I told him, "General saab, you keep harping about India, do you think Pakistan can really conquer our country?" He was dumbstruck for few seconds and said, "No." Then I fired another question. "Do you think India wants to conquer Pakistan?" General Gul smiled this time and said, "Yes." Then I said, "General saab, this is your real problem, you have a sense of insecurity." Gul got a little agitated and whispered to me that Pakistan would bleed India in Kashmir. I said, "General saab, you have no sense of history. A nation has a long life, don't forget that."' This verbal confrontation left General Gul hugely embarrassed and he retreated.

The attack on the USA in 2001 had changed the security and strategic dynamics in this part of the world. The ISI and the Pakistan army made a tactical retreat to show they were siding with America and its allies to fight terror but they were recalibrating their next moves, targeting the Afghan and Indian theatres. The R&AW spies had served India well.

At least in the Afghanistan-Pakistan border area, they had raised a good number of covert operators and within the